

Ideation

Our group discussed 6 potential ideas before landing on our app: Knit. Each idea expressed drew interest from the entire group; thus, it was difficult to narrow it down to one. Below is a list and description of each app idea.

Proposed app ideas:

Find a Buddy (Karen)

- An app that connects people with all kinds of shared hobbies. The easy way to find your friend group and branch out.

Pokémon (Henry)

- One stop hub for all things Pokémon, includes a social page that shows cool cards you/friends pulled, portfolio, AI card grader, leaderboards, and a map of stores that sell cards.

Thriftng (Andreanna)

- Thriftng can be a stressful hobby, an app that helps enthusiasts know what to expect before leaving their house would be greatly beneficial and save time. Inventory reports.

FishedIn (Henry)

- Crowdsource fishing app where users can AI identify fish they caught which populates the map with data, allows for others to find locations with fish they want to catch.

Strava Live (Henry)

- An augmented version of the popular running app Strava, users can see which friends are running and send text to speech messages, including AI coach, shoe recommendations, etc.

College Course Advising (Sky)

- An app that breaks up uncertainty when it comes to picking up college courses. The assistant would provide more insight than a traditional quick advising meeting.

Ultimately, we decided on the Find a Buddy idea and rebranded to an app named Knit. Our entire group acknowledged the hardships of finding people interested in a niche hobby; it can be difficult to put yourself into new social situations. As a result, we are motivated to develop an app that changes the social landscape everywhere and helps people build confidence to meet others.

Knit: Unravel Your Weekend

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Abstract—The Weavers (Team 8) will be creating an app called “Knit” in response to the changing dynamics observed in this college town. People come and go, and individuals with whom one once shared hobbies may no longer be in the same town after graduating. There are times when an individual would like to find someone to join them in an activity, such as running, playing board games, or practicing a dance, but they may not know where to find people who are also interested in participating. Currently, invitations to participate in group activities are often scattered across different platforms, such as Facebook, Reddit, and group chats. Therefore, the Weavers would like to create an app that brings people with similar interests together, allows them to participate in activities, and helps them build new friendships.

Keywords— *social networking, community building, college community*

I. INTRODUCTION

College towns are constantly changing as students move, graduate, and develop new social schedules or social circles. Because of this, people may want to join an activity or attend a local event but struggle to find others who are interested and available. Current options, such as Facebook, Reddit, and group chats, are scattered across different platforms and often depend on existing communities. Knit aims to provide one place where users can find activity partners, organize plans, and connect with people who share similar interests.

II. MOTIVATION

A. Problem Statement

College towns are constantly changing as undergraduate students, graduate students, and international students move into and out of the community. Students may be interested in activities such as running, playing board games, attending local events, or practicing a hobby but may not have friends who are available or interested in joining them. This can be particularly challenging for graduate students, including PhD students, whose schedules and social opportunities may differ from those of undergraduate students, as well as international students who may be unfamiliar with the local community and looking to establish new social connections [1, 2]. Although platforms such as Facebook, Reddit, and group chats provide ways to share activities and invitations, these opportunities are often scattered across different platforms and communities. As a result, students may not know where to find potential activity partners outside of their existing social circles. There is a need for a centralized

platform that makes it easier for students to discover activities and connect with others based on shared interests.

B. Impact of the Problem

The difficulty of finding activity partners can limit students' opportunities to participate in social activities and develop new friendships. Students who are new to a college town, have demanding academic schedules, or have seen their existing friends graduate may face additional challenges when trying to expand their social circles. International students may also experience barriers when entering an unfamiliar community and attempting to establish new relationships. When students do not know where or how to form new friendships, they may experience feelings of loneliness and social isolation. Persistent loneliness and social isolation can negatively affect mental well-being and are associated with adverse mental health outcomes over time [3]. Research on university students suggests that interventions promoting social interaction and social connectedness can help reduce loneliness [4]. By making it easier for students to discover activities and meet people with similar interests, Knit could reduce barriers to social connection, encourage participation in the local community, and help students build meaningful and lasting friendships.

III. PROPOSED FEATURES

A. Find Hobbies

The Find Hobbies feature allows users to connect with other users by finding similar hobbies. This is a place where users can search for any open invitations to participate in an activity, where the activity's location is, and when the activity is going to happen. It is a starting point for users to begin exploring Knit.

B. Heat Map

When a user opens Knit, they can select the location they are currently at. The app then provides information about how many people are registered in the app within a specific location, as well as the recent activities those users have participated in. On the Heat Map page, users can also see a list of the top activities that people nearby enjoy participating in.

C. Suggestions/Recommendations

When a user signs up for the app, they will be asked a series of questions to identify their hobbies and interests. This information will help the app personalize the activities

suggested on their feed and give them a starting point for exploring new activities.

D. Recent Activities in Your Area

A feature that will help choose potential activities that students can participate in is recent activities. In this feature, a list of past activities will be included to see what kinds of sports, games, and hobbies are available. It could guide users to experience new activities they may have not been aware of beforehand.

E. Alert/Messages/Friend list

One of the core features of any social app is messaging. This feature on Knit will allow users to add friends, message them, and create group chats. The friends list also contains a section thatThe app will also include a notifications section that alerts users of messages or activities near them that they are interested in.

IV. APPLICATION FUNCTIONALITY

Knit is designed to make it easier for students to find people to participate in activities with. The application focuses on student engagement by allowing users to discover activities, find people with similar interests, and communicate with potential activity partners. Instead of requiring students to already be part of an established social group, Knit gives them an opportunity

to meet others through shared interests and activities. The main functionalities include finding hobbies, a heat map, suggestions/recommendations, recent activities, and messages. These features aim to make meeting people more approachable by connecting students with the activities they enjoy.

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